

REVERIE: 2040

Just another day in a future AI-assisted India
for a Digit writer

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"BEEP! BEEP!" said some stupid thing in my dream. "Shut up!" I mumbled. It shut up. Then my favourite song came on. It started off soft, but grew louder. I couldn't help it, and my feet started tapping to the beat. As much as I wanted to sleep, I had no choice but to wake up. "That's new," I said out loud as I opened my eyes. "I thought you'd like it," said APSaRA. Even in my thoughts I hated that acronym – Artificial Public Services and Robotic Assistant. It was obvious someone called her 'Apsara' first, and later made it an acronym for something longer, but it had just grown on all of us now. I was determined to undo the brain-washing though, and forced myself to think "Apsara, like a normal name."

"Good morning Dear!" said an almost strange, but sweet voice. I was startled back to reality and looked in no particular direction to find this new voice with no body, before I remembered that I had signed up for the new 'Life Coach' feature of Apsara last night. I was already missing my

earlier 'High School Sweetheart' hack, but I was done testing it, had written my article, and as much as I missed her, I knew that hacking the APSaRA network was very illegal. Darn it. That damn acronym.

"I've turned the water heater on, it will take 15 minutes. Do you want to take a quick jog in that time? You've gained 1.3 kilos since last week, and all of it around your stomach area," sang Apsara. Apparently this modification had her sounding like a modern mother. "Why on earth would people pay to be nagged by a mother?" I thought to myself. "No I don't want to jog, and remind me to call mum this evening," I barked at Apsara. I immediately felt guilty. It's a good thing I got rid of the sweetheart mod... guilty? Why was I feeling guilty for ordering a machine around? I decided to switch to the 'Slave Mod' the minute I was done testing this silly Life Coach one. I couldn't afford therapy, and developing feelings for a machine that was omnipresent would require a lot of therapy to fix. Nothing like an AI calling you "Master" to remind you that it was nothing more than a service.

I stepped into the shower, and was lost in the feeling of warm water as my state government mandated auto-bather went to work. Maharashtra was

officially a water conserving state, and these auto-bathers, which were also controlled by Apsara, used under 25% of water as a regular shower. Suddenly the water turned off. Apparently my bath was done.

"Get dressed soon, or else you'll be late for work," demanded APSaRA. I didn't mind the acronym format anymore. She was irritating me. I would probably delete this avatar of her the instant the mandatory week of reviewing was done. I could already foresee a low rating for this mod.

I went back to daydreaming as I got ready in autopilot mode. Why did we have to work? People in Germany, Sweden and Denmark didn't work. I wished I could go live there to experience it. Was almost impossible since the world shut down all borders. Most of Europe could still freely travel, but it was an exclusive club. Everyone wanted to go there. Being paid to sit at home and paint, or create music, or follow your passions sounded like a dream. India's population was too large, it would never happen here. Heck, our cities had already closed borders to village folk. Life outside the cities was hard, and unforgiving. Suddenly I felt lucky again. None of India was as bad as the US though. It was anarchy there, and they'd almost destroyed themselves. Once AI